

HUMAN RESOURCES · POLICY MANUAL

Employee Handbook

Policies, benefits, conduct standards and escalation procedures for all employees, contractors and interns of Northwind Systems Private Limited.

Document owner	People Operations, Mumbai
Approved by	M.I Shaikh, Chief People Officer
Version	4.2 (supersedes 4.1, dated 12 Jun 2025)
Review cycle	Annual — next review 01 Apr 2027
Applies to	All locations: Bengaluru, Pune, remote

TABLE OF CONTENTS

- 1. Purpose and Scope
- 2. Employment Basics and Classification
- 3. Working Hours, Attendance and Remote Work
- 4. Compensation and Payroll
- 5. Leave and Time Off
- 6. Benefits and Reimbursements
- 7. Code of Conduct
- 8. Information Security and Acceptable Use
- 9. Grievance Redressal and Escalation Matrix
- 10. Performance, Progression and Exit
- 11. Appendix A — Glossary
- 12. Appendix B — Revision History

1. Purpose and Scope

This handbook describes the terms, expectations and entitlements that govern employment at Northwind Systems Private Limited ("Northwind", "the Company"). It is issued under the authority of the Chief People Officer and applies from 01 April 2026 to every person engaged by the Company, including full-time employees, fixed-term contractors, interns and consultants working on Company premises or systems.

Where a provision of this handbook conflicts with a written employment agreement, a statutory requirement, or a location-specific addendum, the more specific document prevails. Where a provision conflicts with local law, local law prevails and the remainder of the handbook remains in force.

NOTE

This handbook is not an employment contract and does not create one. The Company may amend any policy at its discretion; material changes are communicated at least 15 calendar days before they take effect.

1.1 How to use this document

Each section is numbered for citation in tickets and correspondence — for example, "per HB §9.3" refers to the escalation timelines table. Defined terms appear in Appendix A and are capitalised throughout.

- Policies marked **Mandatory** carry disciplinary consequences if breached.
- Policies marked **Guidance** describe expected practice but allow manager discretion.
- Anything not addressed here should be raised with People Operations at people@northwind.example.

2. Employment Basics and Classification

Every engagement at Northwind falls into one of five classifications. Classification determines eligibility for leave, benefits, notice periods and equity participation.

Class	Description	Probation	Notice	Benefits
FT-R	Full-time regular	90 days	60 days	Full
FT-P	Full-time probationary	90 days	15 days	Medical only
FTC	Fixed-term contract (≤ 24 months)	30 days	30 days	Pro-rated

Class	Description	Probation	Notice	Benefits
PT	Part-time (≤ 24 hrs/week)	60 days	30 days	Pro-rated
INT	Intern / apprentice	None	7 days	Stipend only

Table 2.1 — Employment classifications and associated entitlements.

2.2 Confirmation of employment

Probationary employees are reviewed at day 45 (informal) and day 85 (formal). A confirmation decision must be recorded in Workbench before day 90; absent a recorded decision, the employee is automatically confirmed. Probation may be extended once, by a maximum of 60 days, with written justification approved by the function head.

3. Working Hours, Attendance and Remote Work

The standard working week is 40 hours across five days. Core collaboration hours are 11:00–16:00 in the employee's registered time zone; outside core hours, schedules are flexible subject to team agreement.

3.1 Work location models

Model	On-site requirement	Approval	Stipend (per month)
Office-based	5 days/week	Default	—
Hybrid	2 days/week, Tue + Thu	Manager	₹2,000
Remote (domestic)	4 days/quarter	Function head	₹4,500
Remote (cross-border)	None	CPO + Tax	Per addendum

Table 3.1 — Work location models. Cross-border remote work exceeding 30 days triggers a permanent-establishment review.

3.2 Attendance and unplanned absence

Unplanned absence must be notified to the reporting manager before 10:00 local time on the day of absence. Three or more consecutive unnotified absence days are treated as abandonment of duty and trigger the process described in §10.4.

1. Notify the manager by call or message; email alone is insufficient.
2. Log the absence in Workbench within 24 hours of return.
3. Absences of three or more consecutive days require a medical certificate.

3.3 Overtime and on-call

Non-exempt employees who work beyond 45 hours in a week accrue compensatory time at 1.25× or, where local law requires, overtime pay. On-call rotations are capped at one week in four; on-call allowance is ₹1,200 per weekday night and ₹2,500 per weekend day. A person who is paged between 00:00 and 06:00 may start the following workday no earlier than 13:00 without using leave.

CAUTION

Compensatory time expires 90 days after it is accrued and is not paid out at exit. Managers are responsible for scheduling its use.

4. Compensation and Payroll

Salaries are paid monthly on the last working day, covering the calendar month. Payslips are published to Workbench within two working days of disbursement. Annual compensation reviews are effective 01 July each year and are based on the performance rating described in §10.1.

Component	Basis	Frequency	Taxable
Base salary	Grade band midpoint ± 20%	Monthly	Yes
Performance bonus	0–25% of base, rating-linked	Annual	Yes
Referral award	₹50,000–₹1,50,000 by grade	On event	Yes
Equity (RSU)	4-year vest, 1-year cliff	Quarterly	At vest
Learning wallet	₹40,000 per financial year	On claim	No

Table 4.1 — Compensation components. Figures are indicative for the India entity; other entities follow local addenda.

5. Leave and Time Off

The leave year runs from 01 January to 31 December. All leave is applied for in Workbench and requires manager approval before it is taken, except emergency sick leave, which may be regularised within two working days.

Leave type	Entitlement	Accrual	Carry-forward	Encashable
Earned / privilege	21 days	1.75/month	Max 15 days	Yes, at exit
Sick	12 days	Front-loaded	No	No
Casual	7 days	Front-loaded	No	No
Maternity	26 weeks	Statutory	N/A	No
Paternity / partner	4 weeks	Per event	N/A	No
Bereavement	5 days	Per event	N/A	No
Sabbatical	Up to 12 weeks	After 5 years	N/A	Unpaid
Public holidays	10 fixed + 2 floating	Calendar	No	No

Table 5.1 — Leave entitlements for FT-R employees, India entity. Pro-rated for FTC, PT and mid-year joiners.

5.2 Approval thresholds

- 1–3 days: reporting manager.
- 4–10 days: reporting manager and skip-level manager.
- 11+ days or any leave during a code freeze: function head, with a documented cover plan.
- Negative leave balance: People Operations only, capped at 5 days.

6. Benefits and Reimbursements

Group medical cover is provided from the date of joining, with no waiting period for pre-existing conditions. Coverage is ₹7,00,000 per family floater per year, including the employee, spouse or partner, up to two children and two dependent parents or parents-in-law.

6.1 Expense claim limits

Category	Limit	Receipt required	Settlement SLA
Domestic travel — air	Economy, lowest logical fare	Yes	7 working days
Hotel — metro	₹6,500 / night	Yes	7 working days
Per diem — domestic	₹1,800 / day	No	With payroll
Home-office setup	₹35,000 once per 3 years	Yes	14 working days
Client entertainment	₹4,000 / head, pre-approved	Yes	14 working days

Table 6.1 — Reimbursement limits. Claims must be filed within 45 days of the expense date.

7. Code of Conduct

Northwind expects honesty, respect and professional judgement from every person representing the Company. The standards below are **Mandatory** and apply on Company premises, at client sites, at Company-sponsored events and on Company communication channels.

7.1 Prohibited conduct

- Harassment, discrimination or retaliation of any kind, including on the basis of gender, caste, religion, disability, age, sexual orientation or nationality.
- Offering, accepting or soliciting bribes, kickbacks or facilitation payments.
- Undisclosed conflicts of interest, including outside employment with a competitor or supplier.
- Trading in Company or client securities while in possession of unpublished price-sensitive information.
- Falsification of records, timesheets, expense claims or performance data.

7.2 Gift policy thresholds

Value	Action required	Register entry
Under ₹2,500	May accept	Not required
₹2,500 – ₹10,000	Manager notification	Within 7 days
Above ₹10,000	Decline or surrender to Company	Mandatory
Any value, from a live bidder	Decline	Mandatory

Table 7.1 — Gift and hospitality thresholds.

8. Information Security and Acceptable Use

All Company data is classified at one of four levels. Handling requirements follow the classification, not the medium: a screenshot of Restricted data is Restricted.

Level	Examples	Storage	External sharing
Public	Marketing site, job posts	Any	Unrestricted
Internal	Org charts, roadmaps	Company drive	NDA required
Confidential	Contracts, salary data	Access-controlled	Legal approval
Restricted	Customer PII, keys, source	Encrypted vault	Prohibited

Table 8.1 — Data classification and handling matrix.

8.2 Device and credential standards

Company-issued laptops must remain enrolled in mobile device management, run full-disk encryption and receive security patches within 14 days of release. Personal devices may access email and chat only, through the managed application container.

```
Minimum password policy (enforced by SSO)
length           >= 14 characters
reuse window     last 10 passwords
rotation         365 days, or immediately on suspected compromise
MFA              hardware key or TOTP; SMS not permitted
session          12 hours idle, 7 days absolute
```

Figure 8.1 — Credential policy as enforced in the identity provider.

WARNING

Suspected data breaches must be reported to security@northwind.example within one hour of discovery. Do not attempt to remediate or delete evidence before the security team responds.

9. Grievance Redressal and Escalation Matrix

Any employee may raise a concern without fear of retaliation. Concerns are handled at the lowest appropriate level and escalated when the owner at that level does not resolve the matter within the stated response window.

9.1 Severity definitions

Severity	Definition	Examples
S1 — Critical	Risk to safety, legal exposure, or protected-category harm	Harassment, assault, bribery, data breach
S2 — High	Policy violation affecting a team or a customer commitment	Expense fraud, repeated abusive conduct
S3 — Medium	Individual dispute or entitlement error	Leave rejection dispute, payroll discrepancy
S4 — Low	Request, clarification or facilities issue	Seating, equipment, policy interpretation

Table 9.1 — Grievance severity definitions.

9.2 Escalation matrix

Level	Owner	Handles	First response	Resolution target	Escalates to
L0	Reporting manager	S3, S4	1 working day	5 working days	L1
L1	HR Business Partner	S2, S3	1 working day	10 working days	L2
L2	Function head + Head of People Ops	S2	2 working days	15 working days	L3
L3	Internal Committee (ICC / Ethics)	S1, S2	24 hours	30 calendar days	L4
L4	Chief People Officer	S1	24 hours	45 calendar days	L5
L5	Audit Committee of the Board	S1, appeals	5 working days	60 calendar days	External / statutory

Table 9.2 — Escalation matrix. S1 matters bypass L0–L2 and are raised directly at L3.

9.3 Escalation timelines and channels

Concern type	Entry point	Channel	Anonymous?
Sexual harassment	L3 — ICC	icc@northwind.example	No (statutory)
Fraud, bribery, ethics	L3 — Ethics	Speak-Up portal	Yes
Payroll or benefits error	L1 — HRBP	Workbench ticket	No
Manager conduct	L1 — HRBP	people@northwind.example	Yes
Workplace safety	L2 — Facilities lead	safety@northwind.example	Yes

Table 9.3 — Entry points by concern type.

NON-RETALIATION

Retaliation against a complainant, witness or investigator is itself an S1 matter and is grounds for termination, irrespective of the outcome of the underlying complaint.

10. Performance, Progression and Exit

10.1 Rating scale

Rating	Label	Indicative distribution	Bonus multiplier
5	Transformative	5%	1.75×
4	Exceeds expectations	20%	1.30×
3	Meets expectations	60%	1.00×
2	Partially meets	12%	0.50×
1	Does not meet	3%	0×

Table 10.1 — Performance ratings. Distribution is a guideline for calibration, not a forced curve.

10.2 Performance improvement plan

A rating of 1, or two consecutive ratings of 2, initiates a Performance Improvement Plan (PIP) of 60 days. A PIP must state measurable outcomes, weekly checkpoints and the consequence of non-achievement. The employee may request HRBP attendance at any checkpoint.

10.3 Resignation and notice

Resignations are submitted in Workbench and acknowledged within two working days. Notice periods are per Table 2.1. Notice buyout is permitted at the function head's discretion at the rate of one day of gross salary per day waived. Full and final settlement is released within 45 days of the last working day.

10.4 Exit checklist

1. Knowledge transfer document approved by the reporting manager.
2. Return of laptop, access card, hardware key and any Company-funded equipment.
3. Revocation of all system access, completed by IT on the last working day.
4. Exit interview with the HRBP, scheduled within the final week.
5. Confirmation of forwarding address and bank details for settlement.

Appendix A — Glossary

CPO

Chief People Officer; final internal authority on all policy in this handbook.

HRBP

HR Business Partner; the People Operations contact assigned to a function.

ICC

Internal Complaints Committee constituted for sexual-harassment matters.

PIP

Performance Improvement Plan; a time-bound plan following a low rating.

Workbench

The Company's internal HR system of record for leave, payroll and tickets.

Working day

Monday to Friday excluding declared public holidays at the employee's registered location.

Appendix B – Revision History

Version	Date	Summary of change	Approver
4.2	01 Apr 2026	Added L5 Audit Committee tier; revised remote stipends	MI Shaikh
4.1	12 Jun 2025	Sabbatical policy introduced; learning wallet raised to ₹40,000	MI Shaikh
4.0	03 Feb 2024	Full rewrite; four-level data classification adopted	A. Shaikh
3.3	19 Sep 2022	Hybrid work model formalised post-pandemic	A. Shaikh

Table B.1 – Revision history. Superseded versions are retained by Legal for seven years.

Acknowledgement: by continuing employment after the effective date, the employee confirms having read and understood this handbook. A signed acknowledgement is collected in Workbench within 14 days of issue.